

cooperation between the forces. Such techniques eventually evolved in action, first in the North African desert and then in Italy after the Allied invasion of 1943. These experiences left the Allies reasonably well prepared for the large-scale use of aircraft in support of the armies in Normandy.

Without air superiority the D-Day landings could not even have been attempted. As it was, Allied fighters largely insulated their ground forces and shipping from air attack, while the first wave of the invasion included the flying in

of three airborne divisions by parachute and glider. Allied bombers and fighter-bombers had destroyed bridges and other communication links in northwest France so comprehensively that the region was virtually cut off. German attempts to move in reinforcements and supplies encountered constant harassment from marauding aircraft, until movement was hardly possible. On the front line, heavy bombers were used for the first time to "carpet-bomb" enemy positions in preparation for an offensive. By 1944 no artillery barrage

could match the awesome quantity of explosives delivered by a bomber squadron.

Close air support was not without its problems. Determined efforts were made to bring air power to bear on the right targets at the right time, but under battle conditions this was never easy. Forward air controllers, either on the ground or airborne in light aircraft over the front (another innovation of this period), would call in and direct air-strikes, while various indicators such as smoke or flares were used to help identify targets. But



POWERFUL TYPHOON

Introduced as a fighter in 1941, the RAF's Hawker Typhoon was initially a flop, suffering a spate of engine and structural failures. Later in the war it was switched to a ground-attack role with devastating effect, proving ruggedly resistant to enemy fire and packing a powerful payload of bombs and air-to-ground rockets.



NORMANDY LANDINGS

American troops wade ashore on D-Day, June 6, 1944. This vast amphibious operation would have been impossible to attempt without air superiority, and extensive bombing of bridges, roads, and railroads in northern France before the invasion made it impossible for the Germans to rush reinforcements to Normandy.



ROCKET ATTACK

This is the view from an RAF Typhoon as it fires a rocket at German vehicles on a road in Normandy in 1944. The Typhoons became renowned for the tank-busting power of their rocket attacks, though with unguided weapons the odds were always against a direct hit.